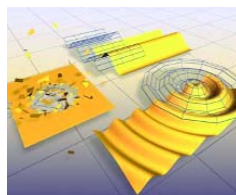




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Technology Beyond Work

Swapnil Dhamankar and Tausef Syed are just two among the thousands of NGO beneficiaries in the country. Here's how technology connects them

Touched by Tech

A Site to Give

Garfield D'Souza

If he ever featured on a music television countdown show, its producer would put Tausef Syed in the "bubbling under" segment. Tausef is 15, and like most teenagers his age, likes Aishwarya Rai and Hrithik Roshan. He loves mathematics at school, and he wants to be a pilot when he grows up.

Tausef works in a garage. His enthusiasm belies his financial status—his father, Latif, is a contract labourer and just about earns enough to feed his family.

Tausef's energy and zest for life could well be because he is confident his education costs—pencils, books, paper—would be taken care of by Apnalaya, a Mumbai-based NGO that specialises in child welfare and education.

Swapnil Dhamankar is 19. He quit school when he was in the seventh standard, but he plans to live life on his own terms. His ambitions are, well, not even ambitions really. Swapnil wants to become a good tailor, and spends most of his time "studying" for his tailoring course. He also earns a stipend of Rs 500, and says he



"I'm not sure what I plan to be in life, but work I will

Swapnil Dhamankar

will earn more in the future. Much more.

Swapnil is deaf. He is gung-ho about the future, though—he has the support of the National Society for Equal Opportunities for the Handicapped (NASEOH).

What connects the two is a Web site called GiveIndia.org, an online channel that lets people donate to the NGO and the cause of their choice. Various NGOs get listed on the site so that people can donate to the NGO of their choice.

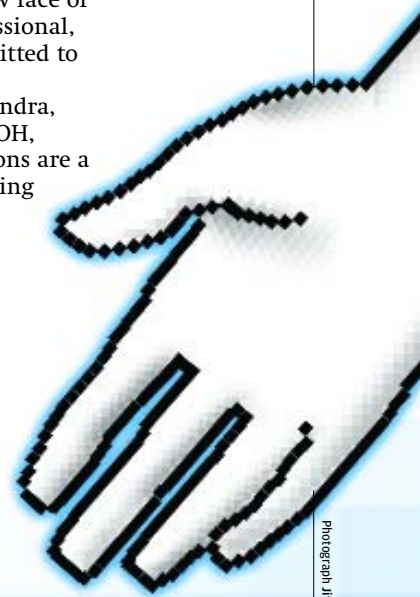
It is an idea as simple as they come—a supra NGO that lists various NGOs after carefully going through their credentials. Says GiveIndia director Venkat Krishnan: "Our hope was that a channel like this will give small, relatively unknown NGOs a chance to reach out to donors all over India and the world. The emphasis is also on promoting giving in a transparent, efficient and effective manner."

Every NGO has its financial statements listed, with a break-up of how the donated money would be used. They are also classified according to states and various social causes.

Take your pick. GiveIndia, in a way, represents the new face of the Indian NGO—professional, transparent and committed to the cause.

Says Sudha Balachandra, director general, NASEOH, agrees: "Online donations are a methodical way of getting funds, and GiveIndia is transparent in their functionality."

Adds Apnalaya head Leena Joshi: "Most of the visitors to the site are casual surfers. But for NGOs like us, awareness is of prime importance." Dr A Goswami of Child Aid Foundation, an NGO based in Vijayawada, Andhra



Photograph: Iken Gandhi; Imaging: Atul Deshmukh